

Preserving School Air as Admissible Evidence

From environmental monitoring to authorized intervention | Technical governance reference v2.0 | 8 October 2026

STATUS: INDEPENDENT PRE-EXAMINATION | BASELINE NOT FROZEN | NO FORMAL DISPOSITION

This is a proposed educational governance method, not a review of any actual school, a performance certification, legal opinion, or endorsement by USGBC, the Center for Green Schools, EPA, or a participating district. The examples and sample records are hypothetical.

The institutional governing question

Does this proposed consequence have sufficient Admissible Evidence, Applicable Authority, and Established Standing to become reality NOW?

1 | Executive determination and public context

A school can have a credible indoor air quality (IAQ) plan, calibrated sensors, and technically capable operators without having an explicit, reviewable record authorizing a particular intervention at a particular moment. TA14 proposes a separate decision boundary: preserve what was observed; establish evidentiary fitness; identify applicable authority and standing; constrain any permitted action; and verify the outcome. This is a proposed complement to, not a replacement for, district IAQ planning or emergency procedures.

Facility Executive reported that the 2026-2027 Center for Green Schools School Air Quality Fellowship includes 53 school-system leaders from 25 states serving more than two million students, with a nine-month program from September 2026 to May 2027. The article describes an energy-efficient IAQ planning toolkit and EPA assistance agreement 5V84097801. These are attributed article claims, not findings independently verified by TA14.

2 | What must be preserved before interpretation

Evidence class	Minimum contextual record
Air and comfort	CO2, PM2.5, temperature, relative humidity where available; units, averaging periods, location and uncertainty
Ventilation and equipment	Outdoor-air state, supply/extract flow or proxies, setpoints, fan operation, filter condition, alarms and maintenance history
Context	Occupancy, room use, weather, nearby sources, operating schedule and relevant complaint history
Provenance	Instrument identity, calibration/maintenance status, clock synchronization, raw data, custodian and transfer log

CO2 can inform ventilation assessment in context but is not a comprehensive measurement of exposure or all indoor contaminants. Sensor trends, models, and inferred causes must remain distinct from direct observations.

3 | Eight-stage decision architecture

Stage	Required proof / question	If missing
01 REALITY	Describe actual space, occupants, conditions and equipment before disturbance.	HOLD interpretation
02 RECORD	Capture time, source, units, raw values, instrument identity and operator.	HOLD evidence claim
03 CONTINUITY	Retain original data, custody, corrections and versions; distinguish adjusted values.	HOLD reliance
04 ADMISSIBILITY	Assess integrity, relevance, uncertainty, coverage and fitness for proposed decision.	HOLD or ESCALATE
05 BINDING	Tie evidence and proposed action to exact asset, people, rules and local authority.	HOLD authority
06 COMMIT	Identify decision maker, standing, disposition, action limits and expiry.	No permission
07 EXECUTION	Act only inside approved scope; log actor, time, changes and exceptions.	Stop / ESCALATE
08 OUTCOME	Measure effects and unintended consequences; revalidate changed context.	Reopen review

4 | Distinct responsibilities; no implied delegation

District/owner: establish policy, risk acceptance and accountable asset ownership. **Facilities lead:** manage operating scope and records within delegated authority. **Environmental professional:** assess measurements and uncertainty, without assuming permission to alter equipment. **Engineer/design professional:** evaluate technical implications within professional scope. **Contractor/technician:** perform authorized work within competence and license requirements. **Automation/AI:** observe, recommend, or execute only within a documented and locally established authorization envelope. Exact roles vary by jurisdiction, contract and district policy; they must be mapped, not presumed.

5 | Worked example: elevated classroom CO2

Hypothetical trigger: During occupied hours, a classroom CO2 sensor shows a sustained increase. A controller recommends increasing outdoor-air flow. No numerical threshold or diagnosis is assumed here.

Evidence packet: preserve raw readings and timestamp, instrument position and status, occupancy, outdoor conditions, current damper/airflow state, setpoint history, recent maintenance, and any available corroborating measurement. Record what is observed separately from suspected causes.

Admissibility gate: check sampling coverage, calibration, plausibility, competing explanations, representativeness and uncertainty. If sensor health or provenance cannot be established, HOLD the automated change pending appropriate review.

Authority gate: identify the school/district approver, system owner, approved operating range, applicable code and policy constraints, humidity and pressure effects, adjacent-zone impacts, and rollback condition. Capability to issue a BAS command is not proof of authority.

Commit and execution: document ALLOW, HOLD, DENY or ESCALATE; if ALLOW, record bounded setpoint change, actor/system identity, timestamp, expiry, exception handling and revalidation triggers. Capture actual command and equipment response separately.

Outcome: compare before/after conditions over a specified interval; review CO2 and other relevant parameters, occupant context and secondary impacts. A commanded change is not evidence of successful environmental improvement.

6 | Sample dispositions - illustrative only

Disposition	Illustrative basis
ALLOW	Evidence is sufficiently fit; approver has standing; action and operating envelope are explicit.
HOLD	Instrument integrity, occupancy context or authorization is incomplete.
DENY	Proposed action conflicts with a governing safety or operating constraint.
ESCALATE	A licensed design review, district decision maker, or safety authority is required.

7 | Changed-context revalidation

Reopen the decision when the asset configuration changes, a sensor is replaced or recalibrated, occupancy/use changes materially, operating bounds are exceeded, the authorized time window expires, a new safety condition appears, or outcome evidence contradicts the expected result. Derived authority may pass through multiple entities, but execution authority must still be established locally.

8 | Pilot entry and falsifiable success criteria

A voluntary pilot should identify one consenting district/owner, one building and intervention class, the actual authority map, privacy and retention constraints, existing emergency procedures, and a frozen baseline. Pre-register what will be examined, decision thresholds, evidence acceptance rules, logging obligations and stop criteria. Protect student data and minimize personally identifying information.

Demonstration outputs: (1) baseline manifest and chain of custody; (2) asset/authority map; (3) one completed decision packet; (4) execution trace or documented HOLD; (5) post-action verification and exception log; (6) independent limitations statement. Governance success is not a claim that air quality improved; environmental performance requires its own valid measurements.

9 | Eight-image showroom sequence

01 Reality - actual classroom context. 02 Record - source and provenance. 03 Continuity - custody and version history. 04 Admissibility - fitness and uncertainty. 05 Binding - asset and local authority. 06 Commit - explicit disposition. 07 Execution - bounded action. 08 Outcome - verification and revalidation.

10 | Independence, limitations and source

PRE-EXAMINATION; BASELINE NOT FROZEN. No district has been evaluated here. No formal ALLOW/HOLD/DENY/ESCALATE determination has been made for a real site. Illustrations are educational and are not instrument records. Safety-critical incidents must follow applicable emergency procedures and law. This reference is not a substitute for engineering, industrial hygiene, clinical or legal judgment.

Source: Mary Ellen McCandless, "53 Public School Leaders To Take On Indoor Air Quality Challenge," Facility Executive, published September 18, 2026, updated September 21, 2026. Public article supplied by user.